

Annica Wattler

Doctoral Candidate

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Websites: [Personal Website](#) · [University Profile](#)

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development Economics, Gender Economics, Applied Microeconometrics, Policy Evaluation, Labour Economics, Economics of Education, and Health Economics

REFERENCES

- David Stadelmann (Supervisor), University of Bayreuth (david.stadelmann@uni-bayreuth.de)
- Katja Kaufmann, University of Bayreuth (katja.kaufmann@uni-bayreuth.de)
- Djiby Thiam, University of Cape Town (djiby.thiam@uct.ac.za)
- Cristina Bellés Obrero, IAE-CSIC & Barcelona School of Economics (cristina.belles@iae.csic.es)

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) 2023–present

- Expected completion (Dr. rer. pol.): 05/2027
- Working title: “Socio-Economic Development, Education and Living Standards: New Evidence and Perspectives from the Global South”
- Supervisor: Prof. Dr. David Stadelmann

M.A. Development Studies, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) 2020–2022

- Individual Focus: International Development Economics
- Thesis: “The effect of multi-faceted training programmes on the socio-economic status of young females: New evidence from Ghana”
- Supervisors: Prof. Dr. David Stadelmann, Dr. Raymond Frempong
- Final Grade: Very Good (1.1)

Exchange Semester, Nelson Mandela University (Gqeberha, South Africa) 2019

- Courses in Development Economics and Development Studies

B.Sc. International Business, ESB Business School (Reutlingen, Germany) 2016–2020

- Final Grade: Very Good (1.5)

JOB MARKET PAPER

Beyond Average Effects: The Uneven Promise of Child Marriage Bans (*current version*)

Abstract: Child marriage remains widespread even though most countries have adopted a legal minimum marriage age of 18. Previous studies find that reforms rarely delay marriage on average, but evidence on how effects vary across contexts, and on women’s life-cycle outcomes, remains limited. I study the causal effects of child marriage bans (CMBs), reforms setting 18 as the minimum marriage age without a parental-consent exception, combining WORLD policy data with Demographic and Health Surveys from 20 countries that adopted a CMB between 1995 and 2023. Using a regression discontinuity design based on birth-month eligibility, I estimate effects on marital timing and women’s life-cycle outcomes, and how these vary across individual and country characteristics. I find that while CMBs are not effective on average, they do reduce child marriage in countries where its initial prevalence was low, with weaker evidence of similar effects in countries with low adolescent fertility or a pre-reform legal age close to 18, and among girls aged 16 and 17. Independently of marriage timing, CMBs also increase women’s likelihood of marrying a more educated husband and reduce the justification of intimate partner violence. These findings suggest that CMBs can reinforce pre-existing social shifts but cannot independently alter well-established marital institutions.

PUBLICATIONS

Ex-Post Evaluations of Aid Projects: A Cost-Effective Approach

with David Stadelmann. *Journal of Development Studies*, 2025, doi:10.1080/00220388.2025.2489556

Short Abstract: Evaluating targeted aid projects is costly and time intensive, partly because identifying an adequate control group is difficult. We propose a cost-effective approach for ex-post evaluations, consisting of constructing a control group from existing secondary data, such as household surveys, that mirrors the treatment group. We validate the method using data from an educational programme in rural Ghana targeting marginalised, out-of-school adolescent women, a highly specific intervention typical of small-scale development initiatives. We show that accounting for the project's selection criteria is critical when building the control group, and that survey questions administered to the treatment group must match those in the secondary data to ensure comparability.

WORKING PAPERS

A Harmonised Evaluation of All Free Primary Education Policies in Sub-Saharan Africa: Impacts on Women's Reproductive Health

with David Stadelmann and Frederik Wild

Short Abstract: Free Primary Education (FPE) reforms have been widely employed to estimate a causal effect of schooling on women's reproductive health. Yet, reported effects are generally modest and sufficiently heterogeneous that zero average impacts cannot be ruled out. We provide the first region-wide evaluation of 24 FPE countries, applying a unified regression discontinuity framework with bias-corrected and honest inference to reconcile a fragmented evidence base. We document substantial heterogeneity in FPEs' educational effects with little evidence of robust average gains in schooling. Consistent with these findings, we find no robust effects on reproductive health or hypothesised mechanisms such as labour market participation.

CONFERENCES & SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

European Economic Association (EEA) Annual Congress (Dublin, Ireland)	2026
International Conference on Development Economics (Rouen, France)	2026
Meeting of the European Public Choice Society (Madrid, Spain)	2026
Research Workshop Bavarian Graduate Program in Economics (Bamberg, Germany)	2026
Simposio de la Asociación Española de Economía (SAEe) (Barcelona, Spain)	2025
Bavarian PhD Workshop in Development Economics (Erlangen, Germany)	2025
Graduate Seminar in Economics, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany)	2024, 2025, 2026

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor, Seminar in Development Economics	2024–present
• Elective master's seminar, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) • Topic: Education and Economic Development; designed and taught independently	
Instructor, Introduction to Economics: Macroeconomics (Exercises)	2023–present
• Required master's course, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany)	
Student Tutor, Business Mathematics	2017 – 2018

GRADUATE TRAINING

Machine Learning, Bavarian Graduate Program in Economics (BGPE)	2026
Introduction to Coding, SheCodes (HTML, CSS, JavaScript, VS Code)	2025
Barcelona School of Economics Summer School	2024
<i>Course: Regression Discontinuity Designs in Development Economics</i>	
Academic Writing, BGPE	2024
Advanced Econometrics, BGPE (Top 5, instructed by Jeffrey Wooldridge)	2023
Advanced Microeconomics, BGPE	2023

SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

Doctoral Scholarship , German Academic Scholarship Foundation (<i>Studienstiftung des deutschen Volkes</i>)	2023–present
Marianne-Plehn-Programm , Elite Network of Bavaria <i>Provides funding for a 25% part-time position at a Bavarian university</i>	2023–present
GO Research Award , University of Bayreuth <i>Best master's thesis on gender relations and roles from an intersectional perspective</i>	2024
Exposé Scholarship , German Academic Scholarship Foundation	2022–2023
Study Scholarship , German Academic Scholarship Foundation	2018–2022

RELEVANT WORK EXPERIENCE

University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) <i>Research Assistant, Chair of Economic Policy and Economic Development</i>	2023–present
University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) <i>Student Research Assistant, Cluster of Excellence Africa Multiple</i>	2022–2022
ICDP Ghana (Eastern Region, Ghana) <i>Intern, Strategic Approaches to Girls' Education (STAGE) Project</i>	2021–2021
Mobil ISC GmbH (Bayreuth, Germany) <i>Executive Assistant & Key Account Management</i>	2020–2022
ElringKlinger China (Suzhou, China) <i>Intern & Bachelor Thesis Candidate</i>	2019–2020
ElringKlinger AG (Dettingen an der Erms, Germany) <i>Intern & Working Student (Global Sales)</i>	2018
Programa Abrazo (weltwärts) (Asunción, Paraguay) <i>Development Volunteer</i>	2015–2016

FIELD RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Trip on Post-Colonial Development (Namibia) Sponsored by the German Academic Scholarship Foundation Engaged with local NGOs, media outlets, and business leaders to examine post-colonial development and institutional governance in Namibia.	2024
Fieldwork Lead, Fieldwork for Master's Thesis (Eastern Region, Ghana) - Planned and executed an operational field survey in collaboration with a local NGO. - Trained and supervised a local team of enumerators conducting over 250 structured interviews.	2022

SKILLS

Statistical Software: R, Stata, SPSS
Data Management & Tools: Excel, L^AT_EX
Programming: HTML, CSS, JavaScript

LANGUAGES

- German (Native)
- English (C2)
- Spanish (C2)
- French (C1)
- Catalan (Currently enrolled in A2.2, passed A2.1 with 96%)
- Portuguese (A2)